

AI in My World – Ethical Reflection

One AI system I regularly encounter in daily life is the recommendation algorithm used by TikTok and youtube. It basically decides what videos I see on my “For You” page based on what I watch, like, skip, or rewatch. Over time, it kind of learns my habits and keeps feeding me similar content, which can be entertaining but also a bit sticky, like it doesn’t really want me to leave.

From my ethical perspective, fairness is tricky here. The system doesn’t treat all creators equally in practice—smaller creators can struggle to get visibility if they don’t quickly match what the algorithm thinks is “engaging.” That creates an uneven playing field where content that fits trending patterns gets boosted, while other voices quietly disappear.

Accountability is also unclear. If harmful or misleading content spreads, it’s hard to point to a single responsible actor. The algorithm is doing what it was trained to do, the platform sets the incentives, and users just get caught in the middle. So responsibility gets kind of diffused.

Transparency is one of the weakest parts. I don’t actually know why a specific video appears on my feed. I can guess—watch time, engagement, repetition—but it’s not fully explainable in a way that a normal user can understand. It feels more like “it just shows up because it knows you’ll watch it,” which is not very reassuring.

Privacy is a big concern because the system relies heavily on behavioral tracking: how long I pause, what I scroll past, what I rewatch. Even if it’s anonymized, it still feels like a very detailed behavioral profile is being built.

Autonomy is where things get a bit uncomfortable. The system doesn’t force choices, but it heavily nudges them. It can shape what I think is interesting without me actively choosing it. Sometimes I open the app for “five minutes” and then suddenly it’s half an hour later... which is basically the algorithm doing its job a little too well.

A major bias/ethical risk here is engagement bias. The system tends to promote content that triggers strong reactions—humor, outrage, shock, drama—because those keep people watching. The impact is that calmer, more informative, or nuanced content gets pushed down. This can distort how people see reality and even normalize extreme opinions because those perform better in engagement metrics.

This connects directly to the societal issue of disinformation. Since viral content spreads based on engagement rather than truth, misleading videos can spread extremely fast. Even if fact-checking exists, it often can’t keep up with how quickly the algorithm amplifies content. So the system indirectly contributes to misinformation ecosystems.

From my perspective:

- **Does this system benefit or harm me or my community?**
 - Honestly, both. It benefits me because it’s entertaining, helps me discover things quickly, and sometimes even teaches useful stuff. But it also harms in subtle ways—time loss, distraction, and exposure to low-quality or misleading content that spreads faster than it should.
- **Do I think it should be improved or regulated?**
 - Yes. Not in a “ban it” way, but in a “make it less manipulative” way. Some regulation or design constraints would help make it less exploitative, especially around transparency and data usage.
- **One realistic improvement:**
 - A simple but effective improvement would be a visible “why am I seeing this?” explanation for every recommended post, plus an option to switch to a non-personalized feed by default. That would give users more control and make the system’s behavior less of a black box.